WRITING SAMPLE · SYSTEMATIC REVIEW

The Interdependence of Education and Democracy

Reconciling civic education outcomes with political efficacy: a PRISMA-guided systematic review of ten civic engagement datasets, with recommendations for evaluating civic education programs serving marginalized students.

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AUTHOR	**Ciana Sorrentino Wallace, MPA**
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ACADEMIC WORK NOTICE

This paper was originally prepared as graduate coursework at Indiana University's O'Neill School of Public and Environmental Affairs and has been reformatted for portfolio presentation. It expands an issue paper first written for Law and Public Affairs in 2021 into a full systematic review.

The research questions, review protocol, synthesis and recommendations are the author's original work. Figure 1 and Table 1 are redrawn from public National Assessment of Educational Progress (NAEP) data. Prepared for portfolio and professional evaluation purposes.

Abstract

Education is a critical engine of democracy, both promoting and stratifying young people's engagement in the civic life of their communities.

Past studies show that by late adolescence, students have formed ideas about society that are shaped by their socioeconomic status. These ideas constrain marginalized students in the pursuit of civic learning and political efficacy: the belief that they can influence political affairs.

This study examines how civic education programs influence political efficacy, specifically among marginalized students. It draws on critical work on race, class and inequality to explain how socioeconomic characteristics, demographics and political beliefs shape student political efficacy, and builds theoretical pathways for understanding how marginalized groups build and exercise political efficacy within the knowledge economy. It concludes with recommendations for holistic evaluation methods that measure the impact of civic education on political efficacy without setting aside students' lived experiences.

The problem

> "*Democracy is not simply a license to indulge individual whims and proclivities. It is also holding oneself accountable to some reasonable degree for the conditions of peace and chaos that impact the lives of those who inhabit one's beloved extended community.*" *(Aberjhani)*

American democracy is fluid, and the freedoms, rights and rule of law its citizens enjoy must be constantly worked for. An increasingly globalized world has made global citizenship, human rights and inclusion central to the political conversations of every generation. At the same time, trust in democratic institutions is waning while populism and the rejection of international institutions rise, and de-consolidating democracies drift toward less democratic forms of rule with the support of large numbers of their own citizens (Abrego, 2019).

Every political ideology draws a line between idiocentrism, the belief in the power of the individual, and allocentrism, the centering of the collective (Mio, 2020). This tension between individual and collective runs through every moral debate and every legislature. The quality and scope of civic education bears directly on political efficacy, a form of social capital that democracies need to withstand the rise of populism. Schools do not simply teach content; they teach students how to learn, and knowledge itself is "a productive force, an infinite formative reserve or potential" (Ford, 2021).

Statistical support

Civic education receives less attention than other school subjects despite broad agreement on its importance. Since 1998, the National Assessment of Educational Progress (NAEP) civics assessment, "The Nation's Report Card," has consistently found that only about a quarter of eighth-grade students score at or above proficient. The 2018 average score was just three points higher than in 1998 (Figure 1). Over the same period, the eighth-grade population became markedly more diverse (Table 1). These measures suggest that American public schools are not adequately preparing all students for modern civic engagement.

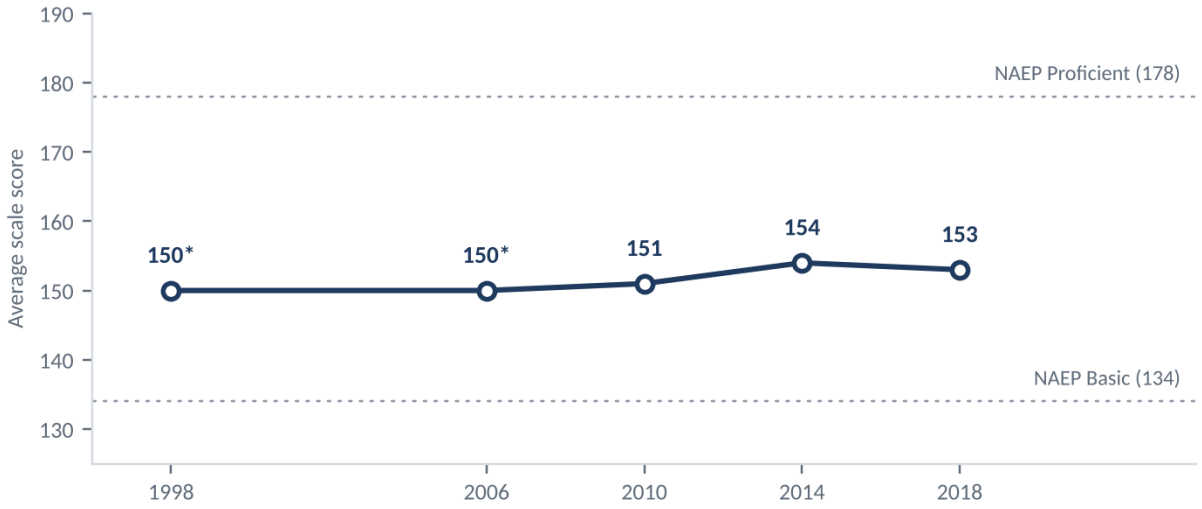


Figure 1. Average NAEP civics scale scores, grade 8, 1998–2018. * Significantly different (p < .05) from 2018. Source: U.S. Department of Education, National Center for Education Statistics, NAEP Civics Assessment.

Year	White	Black	Hispanic	Asian / Pacific Islander	American Indian / Alaska Native	Two or more races
2018	49	14	27	5	1	3
2014	50	15	26	6	1	2*
2010	59*	14	20*	5	1	1*
2006	60*	15	18*	4*	2	1*
1998	70*	15	10*	3*	1	#*

Table 1. Percentage distribution of eighth-grade NAEP civics test takers by race/ethnicity, 1998–2018. * Significantly different (p < .05) from 2018. # Rounds to zero. Source: NCES, NAEP Civics Assessment.

Measurement and the "banking" model

Congressional budgets demand quantitative results from education policy, yet the targets measured are often unrelated to the desired outcomes (Abrego, 2019). Reducing a student's capacity to engage civically to a test score creates a paradox: it simplifies political efficacy to an exam result and sets aside students' lived experiences. This reflects what Freire called the "banking" model of education, in which the student is treated as an empty vessel to be filled. When that model shapes legislation, it reinforces the marginalization of students through its influence on civic education policy.

Participation in public systems as an exercise of political efficacy is shaped by lived circumstances (Merritt et al., 2020). Yet current civic education policy does not address the intersectional challenges marginalized students face in public schools. Civic education gives advantaged students a greater sense of political efficacy than it gives marginalized students (Levinson, 2012). This civic empowerment gap means students in many public school communities have fewer opportunities to develop the skills for full participation in democratic life (Baumann & Brennan, 2017). Civic education must therefore be active rather than passive, maximizing knowledge transfer between teacher as facilitator and student as agent.

Because the education system represents societal ideals of equality while marginalized students experience inequality, we hypothesize that typical civic education policies and curricula do not effectively address the barriers to political efficacy these students face. Marginalized students report higher levels of perceived discrimination and do not receive equitable educational benefit (Malin, Han, & Liauw, 2017).

Law, accountability and a youth-led movement

Legal recognition of civic education matters: a recognized right to civic education and state-mandated programs promote enduring public participation. Public participation, the processes by which people's concerns, needs, interests and values are incorporated into decisions on public issues, upholds democratic values such as transparency, accountability and accessibility. Accountability holds that officials answer to citizens for their decisions and actions (Khademian & Sharif, 2015), and sustained ethical action requires the combined support of the public, practitioners and politicians (Williams, 2015).

Students themselves are recognizing that they are not prepared to participate as citizens. In A.C. v. Raimondo, more than a dozen Rhode Island public school students sued the state in federal court, arguing that by failing to provide an education that prepares them for civic participation, the state violated their rights under the Fourteenth Amendment. The case reflects a youth-centered movement at the intersection of law and social change, led by students who reject civic education that does not address the discrimination they experience.

Purpose of the study

> *"Civic education in a democracy must prepare citizens to participate in and thereby perpetuate the system; at the same time, it must prepare them to challenge what they see as inequities and injustices within that system." (Stanford Encyclopedia of Philosophy)*

There are several empirically supported paths to civic learning. Because dehumanizing approaches to civic education erode political efficacy among marginalized students, evaluation of these programs should take a holistic view of the student–teacher relationship and use qualitative measures of change in political efficacy. This study compares humanizing approaches with the dehumanizing approaches common in the literature, and hypothesizes that awareness and reduction of dehumanization in civic education will produce greater gains in political efficacy for marginalized students. The review is organized around three sets of research questions.

Research questions and literature

Origins: To what extent do civic education reforms influence the political efficacy of marginalized groups?

- **Durkheim (1893/2018); Follert (2020).** Society is an ensemble of ideas, beliefs and sentiments: a collective consciousness of religious beliefs, law, monetary systems and values. These social facts resist individual will, and changing them requires labor, of which education is one form.
- **Freire (1968/2018), Pedagogy of the Oppressed.** Traditional "banking" pedagogy objectifies students as vessels to be filled. Students should be treated as agents and teachers as facilitators, co-creating knowledge together.
- **Levinson (2012), Diversity and Civic Education.** Diversity is an opportunity for students to encounter multiple perspectives and work across difference, but diverse populations report lower political efficacy than advantaged peers and must constantly defend their membership in the American polity.
- **Yoldaş (2015).** Young people see politics as complex; civic education, democratic learning and political participation work together to build political commitment.
- **Mio (2020).** Defines allocentrism and idiocentrism as the individual-level equivalents of collectivism and individualism, and shows that a mismatch between a person's orientation and their society's norms is associated with distress.

Institutions: How do institutions measure accountability in designing and implementing civic education curricula?

- **Measuring political efficacy (1983).** Defines political efficacy as "the feeling that individual political action does have, or can have, an impact upon the political process," divided into internal efficacy (confidence in one's own ability to understand and participate) and external efficacy (belief that institutions are responsive).
- **Shinn (1999), Civic Capacity.** Asks how to manage the tension between individual and collective, and what civic capacity contributes to administrative practice and theory.

- **Keating & Janmaat (2016).** Hands-on "education through citizenship," such as school councils, debate and mock elections, has a lasting, independent effect on youth political engagement.
- **Malin, Han, & Liauw (2017).** Marginalized students' higher perceived discrimination prevents equitable educational benefit, so typical curricula may not address their needs.
- **Geier & Hasager (2020).** Service learning and active-citizenship pedagogies significantly supported students' civic-mindedness and democratic awareness, measured quantitatively and through focus groups.
- **Cohodes & Feigenbaum (2021).** Boston charter school attendance produced large academic gains and increased voter participation.

Solutions: What civic education policies have proven effective, and how can policy diffusion speed change?

- **Pasek et al. (2008), Schools as Incubators of Democratic Participation.** The service-learning "Student Voices" program produced significant gains in political efficacy within two semesters in a large urban district; limitations included reliance on self-reported voting and no ability to isolate which curricular components drove results.
- **Cohen & Chaffee (2013).** Knowledge of American government, current events knowledge, general self-efficacy and skill-specific self-efficacy were each independently associated with adolescents' expected future voting.
- **Kiess (2020).** Experiencing democracy in school or university, such as serving on a student council, increases political trust and participation.
- **Delander & Millard (2014), Education Commission of the States.** Successful civic education policy requires goal-oriented, non-partisan collaboration, coalition-building and strong leadership. Massachusetts, Illinois, Virginia, Alaska and Oregon created task forces; Florida and Tennessee count civics exam performance toward school ratings.
- **Beyond Conflict (2019), Decoding Dehumanization.** A quasi-experimental framework for tracking and reducing dehumanizing speech, designing counter-messaging and evaluating reconciliation programs.
- **Dauer et al. (2021).** Socioscientific instruction builds civic engagement self-efficacy when it connects explicitly to policy decisions.

Significance and state policy landscape

Knowledge is a raw material, created, distributed and consumed in a "ceaseless demand to produce, to actualize, and to realize" (Ford, 2021). This study aims to inform those with the capacity to act in civic settings with the interests of marginalized students in mind. Policymakers and budget committees should re-examine how they measure civic education outcomes to better serve students who report higher levels of perceived discrimination.

Education policy is slow to adopt research recommendations, which contributes to wide variation in civic education across states. The Education Commission of the States' 50-state comparison found that some states, such as California, provide robust civics curricula, while North Dakota and Minnesota rely on third-party organizations for teacher resources (Railey &

Brennan, 2016). All 50 states and the District of Columbia require civics for high school graduation, but requirements range from minimal to specific. Seventeen states use social studies or civics assessment results to report accountability, and twenty provide curriculum frameworks for civics and government instruction.

Methodology

This study uses textual criticism within a mixed-methods framework, guided by a PRISMA systematic review, to analyze how historical student survey datasets have been used in the literature. To examine the relationship between civic education and the political efficacy of marginalized populations, it applies a Durkheimian lens of social capital theory to social program development, and synthesizes the body of evidence qualitatively.

Data: ten civic engagement datasets

Publications drawing on ten major civic engagement datasets were collected for screening:

Dataset	Years	Population and focus	Publications
IEA Civic Education Study	1999	2,811 U.S. ninth graders in 124 schools; civic content knowledge and interpretive skills	123
Civic and Political Health of the Nation	2002	3,246 respondents with a focus on ages 15–25; 19 indicators of civic, electoral and political voice	14
Civic Cohort (Kids Voting USA)	2002–2004	Parent–youth dyads in Arizona, Colorado and Florida; quasi-experimental curriculum intervention	9
Political Engagement Project	2003–2005	21 undergraduate courses and programs; knowledge, skills, motivation and action	13
Colors of Socialization	2006–2007	Panel of high school seniors in five red and five blue states	4
International Civic and Citizenship Education Study	2009	More than 140,000 grade 8 students in 38 countries, plus teachers and principals	191
International Civic and Citizenship Education Study	2016	Successor wave of the international study	146
Stanford Civic Purpose Project	2011–2013	1,578 California high school seniors, with interviews and 9- and 21-month follow-ups	22
The Civic Network	2013	Youth social media use and political engagement in Australia, the UK and the U.S.	9
Critical Consciousness Scale	2016	Validated scale of perceived inequality, egalitarianism and sociopolitical participation	5

Table 2. Datasets included in the systematic review and number of publications drawing on each.

Review framework

Transparency is essential to democracy and should be essential to research about it. Reporting followed the PRISMA statement (Preferred Reporting Items for Systematic Reviews and Meta-Analyses), an evidence-based minimum set of recommendations that lets readers judge how a review was conducted and how trustworthy it is. Qualitative synthesis summarizes the characteristics and findings of the included studies, analyzes relationships among them, identifies gaps in the evidence and assesses its applicability to the research questions.

Inclusion and exclusion criteria

Inclusion and exclusion criteria were adapted from the Critical Consciousness Scale to emphasize marginalized students, and validated against a separate set of civically focused publications from the literature review.

Inclusion criteria	Exclusion criteria
Intervention is a civic education program or course	Point-in-time report
Population is grade 8–12 public school students	Initial population older than high school age
Longitudinal data	Survey of student attitudes or competencies only
Demographics included, with emphasis on race	

Table 3. Inclusion and exclusion criteria.

Findings

Of 622 records imported for screening, 123 duplicates were removed and 496 studies were screened for relevance, of which 138 were excluded. The remaining 357 full-text studies were assessed for eligibility using the PRISMA exclusion criteria, plus an added "not accessible" criterion for studies that were not open access. Seventy-nine studies met all criteria, a resource utilization rate of 15.9 percent.

Stage	Studies remaining	Excluded at this step
Records imported	622	
Screened for relevance (after duplicates removed)	496	138 irrelevant
Full text assessed	357	
Not accessible	248	109
Wrong setting	191	57
Wrong intervention	151	40
Wrong outcomes	124	27
Wrong student population	105	19
Wrong study design	91	14
Wrong comparator	83	8
Wrong indication	80	3
Other	79	1
Studies included	79	

Table 4. PRISMA screening results.

Factors that undermine political efficacy

Older civic education datasets often collected little demographic information, which makes it impossible to study disproportionality in civic learning gains. Program evaluations that rely solely on quantified outcomes do not consider the dehumanization of marginalized students when designing initiatives to strengthen civic education and political efficacy. The limited accessibility of this research also keeps its findings within academia, away from the political actors with the authority to act on them.

Consequences for the knowledge economy

Communication of knowledge is the raw material of an informed, innovative citizenry. When marginalized students collectively experience a lack of political efficacy, that shared experience can itself become a pedagogical force that the knowledge economy cannot easily absorb. But the goal is not to celebrate the absence of political efficacy; learning remains the precondition for participation, just as one must learn to read before one can study a text (Ford, 2021).

The contract between citizens and the state

Durkheim set out to understand social change under industrialization; viewed the same way, education reveals the contractual relationship among citizens, labor and the state. The idea that those in authority are responsible for educating the people they govern is not new; Confucius made the same argument in the Analects. The research coalitions that administered surveys, validated measures and studied political efficacy reflect this sense of responsibility, which must become a cultural norm. The Critical Consciousness Scale captures it in three subscales:

- **Critical reflection: perceived inequality** (items 1–8) measures youths' critical analysis of socioeconomic, racial/ethnic and gendered constraints on educational and occupational opportunity.
- **Critical reflection: egalitarianism** (items 9–13) measures youths' endorsement of societal equality.
- **Critical action: sociopolitical participation** (items 14–22) measures youths' participation in social and political activities to change perceived inequalities.

The civic role of non-governmental institutions

All organizations should pay as much attention to learning as schools do (Ford, 2021). Civic education solutions must counter the idiocentrism that dominates the synthesized literature; allocentric approaches appear in collaborations between public and private stakeholders. Despite recorded increases in volunteerism, service and civic engagement, persistently low voter turnout dominates debate about civic education, and students can show high civic engagement while also exhibiting political apathy.

Recommendations for evaluation and policy

Use impact evaluation to establish causal effects

Findings matter only if they become codified knowledge. An impact evaluation would establish whether civic education programs cause long-term gains in marginalized students' political efficacy, paired with a holistic method for assessing how programs interact with students' existing beliefs and socioeconomic context. This should be a long-term study with generational reach. Realist synthesis can identify what works, how, for whom, why and in what context (Campbell et al., 2011).

To obtain an unbiased estimate of long-term program effects, difference-in-differences estimators should be interacted with students' socioeconomic characteristics and pre-program political beliefs. Common trends across treatment and comparison groups then provide the counterfactual baseline, which yields more reliable estimates than a projected-versus-actual achievement approach (Lewis, 2015).

Anticipate threats to validity

- **Measurement.** Socioeconomic factors and political beliefs will influence results; scores that lack consistency or validity will undermine the evaluation (Mohajan, 2017).

- **Attrition.** Students may not respond across survey waves, and administrators may lose contact after graduation. Email or telephone follow-up helps at the cost of added noise.
- **Self-selection.** Selection based on political interest threatens external validity after graduation; the quality of the comparison group will determine the quality of the evaluation.
- **Inference.** Non-random assignment can exaggerate confounding, and simple standard errors overstate precision. Standard errors should be clustered by school, accepting larger standard errors (Bamberger, 2007).
- **Cost.** Systematic review and realist synthesis are resource-intensive and require deep knowledge of the implementation context, which limits transferability (Campbell et al., 2011).

Policy considerations

- Use assessment flexibility to adopt more innovative measures of civic learning.
- Make holistic measures of civic learning part of education accountability systems.
- Recognize the role of citizenship education in social and emotional development.
- Report on factors beyond standardized academic test results.

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